

PART ONE

The Myths of Creation: The Gods



William Blake, *The Ancient of Days*

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Interpretation and Definition of Classical Mythology



PHAEDRUS: Tell me, Socrates, was it not somewhere around here by the stream of Ilissus that Boreas is said to have carried off Oreithyia?

SOCRATES: That's the story.

PHAEDRUS: It *was* around here, wasn't it? At any rate, the stream is beautiful, pure and clear, and perfect for young girls to play along.

SOCRATES: No, it was down farther. . . . There is an altar there to Boreas, I think.

PHAEDRUS: I didn't know that. But tell me, Socrates, by Zeus, do you believe this story is true?

—PLATO, *Phaedrus* 229b

THE IMPOSSIBILITY OF ESTABLISHING a satisfactory definition of **myth** has not deterred scholars from developing comprehensive theories on the meaning and interpretation of myth, often to provide bases for a hypothesis about its origins. Useful surveys of the principal theories are readily available, so we shall attempt to touch on only a few theories that are likely to prove especially fruitful or are persistent enough to demand attention. One thing is certain: no single theory of myth can cover all kinds of myths. The variety of traditional tales is matched by the variety of their origins and significance; as a result, no monolithic theory can succeed in achieving universal applicability. Definitions of myth will tend to be either too limiting or so broad as to be virtually useless. In the last analysis, definitions are enlightening because they succeed in identifying particular characteristics of different types of stories and thus provide criteria for classification.

The word *myth* comes from the Greek word *mythos*, which means "word," "speech," "tale," or "story," and that is essentially what a myth is: a story. Some would limit this broad definition by insisting that the story must have proved itself worthy of becoming traditional.¹ A myth may be a story that is narrated orally, but usually it is eventually given written form. A myth also may be told by means of no words at all, for

example, through painting, sculpture, music, dance, and mime, or by a combination of various media, as in the case of drama, song, opera, or the movies.

Many specialists in the field of mythology, however, are not satisfied with such broad interpretations of the term *myth*. They attempt to distinguish “true myth” (or “myth proper”) from other varieties and seek to draw distinctions in terminology between myth and other words often used synonymously, such as legend, saga, folktale, and fairytale.²

True Myth or Myth Proper and Saga or Legend

As opposed to an all-encompassing definition for the general term *myth*, **true myth** or **myth proper** is used for stories primarily concerned with the gods and humankind’s relations with them. **Saga** or **legend** (and we use the words interchangeably) has a perceptible relationship to history; however fanciful and imaginative, it has its roots in historical fact.³ These two categories underlie the basic division of the first two parts of this book into “The Myths of Creation: The Gods” and “The Greek Sagas.”

Folktales and Fairytales

In addition to these two categories there are folktales, which are often stories of adventure, sometimes peopled with fantastic beings and enlivened by ingenious strategies on the part of the hero or heroine, who will triumph in the end; their goal is primarily, but not necessarily solely, to entertain. Many of the characters and motifs in folktales are familiar to us all. They are found in both oral and written literature throughout the world, from ancient to the present time, and inevitably will be a source of inspiration for the future, for example, the monstrous giant, the wicked sorceress, the distraught maiden in peril and the special powers of her savior, the wicked sisters, mistaken identity, the imposition of labors, the solving of riddles, the fulfillment of romantic love, and on and on. Among the many folktales in this book, the tale of Cupid and Psyche (see p. 215) offers a particularly splendid example. It begins with “once upon a time” and ends with “happily ever after.”

Fairytales may be classified as particular kinds of folktales, defined as “short, imaginative, traditional tales with a high moral and magical content”; a study by Graham Anderson identifying fairytales in the ancient world is most enlightening.⁴ It is impossible to distinguish rigidly between a folktale and a fairytale, although perhaps a fairytale is often created especially for the young.

The Problems Imposed by Rigid Definitions

Rarely, if ever, do we find a pristine, uncontaminated example of any one of these forms. Yet, the traditional categories of myth, saga, and folktale are useful guides for any attempt to impose some order upon the multitudinous variety of classical tales.⁵ How loose these categories are can be seen, for example, in the legends of Odysseus or of the Argonauts, which contain elements of history (saga) but are full of stories that may be designated as myths and folktales. The criteria for definition merge and the lines of demarcation blur.

Myth and Truth

Since, as we have seen, the Greek word for myth means “word,” “speech,” or “story,” for a critic like Aristotle it became the designation for the plot of a play; thus, it is easy to understand how a popular view would equate myth with fiction. In everyday speech, the most common association of the words *myth* and *mythical* is with what is incredible and fantastic. How often do we hear the expression, “It’s a myth,” uttered in derogatory contrast with such laudable concepts as reality, truth, science, and the facts?

Therefore, important distinctions may be drawn between stories that are perceived as true and those that are not.⁶ The contrast between myth and reality has been a major philosophical concern since the time of the early Greek philosophers. Myth is a many-faceted personal and cultural phenomenon created to provide a reality and a unity to what is transitory and fragmented in the world that we experience—the philosophical vision of the afterlife in Plato and any religious conception of a god are mythic, not scientific, concepts. Myth provides us with absolutes in the place of ephemeral values and with a comforting perception of the world that is necessary to make the insecurity and terror of existence bearable.⁷

It is disturbing to realize that our faith in absolutes and factual truth can be easily shattered. “Facts” change in all the sciences; textbooks in chemistry, physics, and medicine are sadly (or happily, for progress) soon out of date. It is embarrassingly banal but fundamentally important to reiterate the platitude that myth, like art, is truth on a quite different plane from that of prosaic and transitory factual knowledge. Yet, myth and factual truth need not be mutually exclusive, as some so emphatically insist. A story embodying eternal values may contain what was imagined, at any one period, to be scientifically correct in every factual detail; and the accuracy of that information may be a vital component of its mythical raison d’être. Indeed, on one hand, one can create a myth out of a factual story, as a great historian must do: any interpretation of the facts, no matter how credible, will inevitably be a mythic invention. On the other hand, a different kind of artist may create a nonhistorical myth for the ages, and whether or not it is factually accurate may be quite beside the point. A case for discussion is presented by the excerpts from the historical myth of Herotodus, which is translated in Chapter 6.

Myth in a sense is the highest reality, and the thoughtless dismissal of myth as untruth, fiction, or a lie is the most barren and misleading definition of all. The dancer and choreographer Martha Graham, sublimely aware of the timeless “blood memory” that binds our human race and that is continually evoked by the archetypal transformations of mythic art, offers a beautifully concise summation: as opposed to the discoveries of science that “will in time change and perhaps grow obsolete . . . art is eternal, for it reveals the inner landscape, which is the soul of man.”⁸

Myth and Religion

As we stated earlier, true myth (as distinguished from saga and folktale) is primarily concerned with the gods, religion, and the supernatural. Most Greek and Roman stories reflect this universal preoccupation with creation, the nature of god and humankind, the afterlife, and other spiritual concerns.

Thus, mythology and religion are inextricably entwined. One tale or another may have been believed at some time by certain people not only factually but also spiritually; specific creation stories and mythical conceptions of deity may still be considered true today and provide the dogma for devout religious belief in a contemporary society. In fact, any collection of material for the comparative study of world mythologies will be dominated by the study of texts that are, by nature, religious. Greek and Roman religious ceremonies and cults were given authority by myths that inspired belief and therefore afford a recurrent theme in the chapters to follow. Among the examples are the worship of Zeus at Olympia, Athena in Athens, and Demeter at Eleusis, as well as the celebration of other mystery religions throughout the ancient world. The ritualist interpretation of the origins of mythology is discussed later in this chapter. Greek religion is discussed in Chapter 6.

Mircea Eliade

Mircea Eliade, one of the most prolific twentieth-century writers on myth, lays great emphasis on the mystical in his conception of myth: he sees myth as a tale satisfying the yearning of human beings for a fundamental orientation rooted in the religious aura of a sacred timelessness. This yearning is fully satisfied only by stories narrating the events surrounding the beginnings and origins of things. Eliade believes that God, once in a holy era, created the world, and this initial cosmogony becomes the origin myth, the model for creations of every kind and stories about them. He conceives, for example, of a ritual or rite having been performed in a sacred place in this sacred timelessness quite beyond the ordinary or profane space in which we live. His concept develops a difficult, complex mysticism. Like a religious sacrament, myth provides in the imagination a spiritual release from historical time. This is the nature of true myths, which are fundamentally paradigms and explanations and most important to the individual and society.⁹ This definition, which embraces the explanatory nature of mythology, brings us to another universal theory.

Myth and Etiology

Some maintain that myth should be interpreted narrowly as an explication of the origin of some fact or custom. Hence, the theory is called **etiological**, from the Greek word for cause (*aitia*). In this view, the mythmaker is a kind of primitive scientist, using myths to explain facts that cannot otherwise be explained within the limits of society's knowledge at the time. Again, this theory is adequate for some myths, for example, for those that account for the origin of certain rituals or cosmology; but interpreted literally and narrowly, it does not allow for the imaginative or metaphysical aspects of mythological thought.

Yet, if one does not interpret etiological ("the assignment of causes or origins") too literally and narrowly but defines it by the adjective *explanatory*, interpreted in its most general sense, one perhaps may find at last the most applicable of all the monolithic theories. Myths usually try to explain matters physical, emotional, and spiritual not only literally and realistically but also figuratively and metaphorically. Myths attempt to explain the origin of our physical world: the earth and the heavens, the sun, the moon, and the stars; where human beings

came from and the dichotomy between body and soul; the source of beauty and goodness, and of evil and sin; the nature and meaning of love; and so on. It is difficult to tell a story that does not reveal, and at the same time somehow explain, something; and the imaginative answer usually is in some sense or other scientific or theological. The major problem with this universal etiological approach is that it does nothing to identify a myth specifically and to distinguish it clearly from any other form of expression, whether scientific, religious, or artistic—that is, too many essentially different kinds of story may be basically etiological.

Rationalism Versus Metaphor, Allegory, and Symbolism

The desire to rationalize classical mythology arose far back in classical antiquity and is especially associated with the name of Euhemerus (ca. 300 B.C.), who claimed that the gods were men deified for their great deeds (see Chapter 27 on the companion website). The supreme god Zeus, for example, was once a mortal king in Crete who deposed his father, Cronus. At the opposite extreme from **euhemerism** is the metaphorical interpretation of stories. Antirationalists, who favor metaphorical interpretations, believe that traditional tales hide profound meanings. At its best, the metaphorical approach sees myth as allegory (allegory is to be defined as sustained metaphor), where the details of the story are but symbols of universal truths. At its worst, the allegorical approach is a barren exercise in cryptology: to explain the myth of Ixion and the centaurs in terms of clouds and weather phenomena is hardly enlightening and not at all ennobling. (For Ixion and the Centaurs, see pp. 119 and 376.)

Allegorical Nature Myths: Max Müller

An influential nineteenth-century theory was that of Max Müller: myths are nature myths, he said, all referring to meteorological and cosmological phenomena. This is, of course, an extreme development of the allegorical approach, and it is hard to see how or why *all* myths can be explained as allegories of, for example, day replacing night or winter succeeding summer. True, some myths are nature myths, and certain gods, for example, Zeus, represent or control the sky and other parts of the natural order; yet, it is just as true that a great many more myths have no such relationship to nature.¹⁰

Myth and Psychology: Freud and Jung

Sigmund Freud

The metaphorical approach took many forms in the twentieth century through the theories of the psychologists and psychoanalysts, most especially those of Sigmund Freud and Carl Jung. We need to present at least some of their basic concepts, which have become essential for any understanding of mythic creativity. Freud's views were not completely new, of course (the concept of "determinism," for example, "one of the glories of Freudian theory" is to be found in Aristotle),¹¹ but his formulation and analysis of the inner world of humankind bear the irrevocable stamp of genius.

Certainly, methods and assumptions adopted by comparative mythologists—the formulations of the structuralists and the modern interpretation of mythological tales as imaginative alleviating and directive formulations, created to make existence in this real world tolerable—all these find confirmation and validity in premises formulated by Freud. The endless critical controversy in our post-Freudian world merely confirms his unique contribution.

Among Freud's many important contemporaries and successors, Jung (deeply indebted to the master but a renegade) must be singled out because of the particular relevance of his theories to a fuller appreciation of the deep-rooted recurring patterns of mythology. Among Freud's greatest contributions are his emphasis on sexuality (and in particular infantile sexuality), his theory of the unconscious, his interpretation of dreams, and his identification of the **Oedipus complex** (although the term *complex* belongs to Jung). Freud has this to say about the story of King Oedipus:

His fate moves us only because it might have been our own, because the oracle laid upon us before our birth the very curse which rested upon him. It may be that we are all destined to direct our first sexual impulses toward our mothers, and our first impulses of hatred and resistance toward our fathers; our dreams convince us that we were. King Oedipus, who slew his father Laius and wedded his mother Jocasta, is nothing more or less than a wish-fulfillment—the fulfillment of the wish of our childhood. But we, more fortunate than he, in so far as we have not become psychoneurotics, have since our childhood succeeded in withdrawing our sexual impulses from our mothers, and in forgetting the jealousy of our fathers. . . . As the poet brings the guilt of Oedipus to light by his investigation, he forces us to become aware of our own inner selves, in which the same impulses are still extant, even though they are suppressed.¹²

This Oedipal incest complex is here expressed, in the masculine form, of a man's behavior in relationship to his mother, but it also could be expressed in terms of the relationship between daughter and father; the daughter turns to the father as an object of love and becomes hostile to her mother as her rival. For Jung this is an Electra complex.

Dreams for Freud are the fulfillment of wishes that have been repressed and disguised. To protect sleep and relieve potential anxiety, the mind goes through a process of what is termed **dream-work**, which consists of three primary mental activities: "condensation" of elements (they are abbreviated or compressed); "displacement" of elements (they are changed, particularly in terms of allusion and a difference of emphasis); and "representation," the transmission of elements into imagery or symbols, which are many, varied, and often sexual. Something similar to this process may be discerned in the origin and evolution of myths; it also provides insight into the mind and the methods of the creative artist, as Freud himself was well aware in his studies.¹³

Thus, Freud's discovery of the significance of dream-symbols led him and his followers to analyze the similarity between dreams and myths. Symbols are many and varied and often sexual (e.g., objects like sticks and swords are phallic). Myths, therefore, in the Freudian interpretation, reflect people's waking efforts to systematize the incoherent visions and impulses of their sleep world. The patterns in the imaginative world of children, savages, and neurotics are similar and are revealed in the motifs and symbols of myth.

As can be seen from Freud's description in the earlier quote, one of the basic patterns is that of the Oedipus story, in which the son kills the father in order to possess the mother. From this pattern Freud propounded a theory of our archaic heritage, in which the Oedipal drama was played out by a primal horde in their relationship to a primal father. The murder and the eating of the father led to important tribal and social developments, among them deification of the father figure, the triumph of patriarchy, and the establishment of a totemic system, whereby a totem (i.e., a sacred animal) was chosen as a substitute for the slain father. Most important of all, from the ensuing sense of guilt and sin for parricide emerges the conception of God as Father who must be appeased and to whom atonement must be made. In fact, according to Freud, the Oedipus complex inspired the beginning not only of religion but also of all ethics, art, and society.

It is clear that Freud's connection between dreams and myths is illuminating for many myths, if not for all. In addition to the story of Oedipus one might single out, for example, the legend of the Minotaur or the saga of the House of Atreus, both of which deal with some of the most persistent, if repressed, human fears and emotions and, by their telling, achieve a kind of catharsis.

Carl Jung

Jung went beyond the mere connection of myths and dreams to interpret myths as the projection of what he called the **collective unconscious** of the race, that is, a revelation of the continuing psychic tendencies of society. Jung made a distinction between the personal unconscious and the collective unconscious: the personal concerns matters of an individual's own life, whereas the collective embraces political and social questions involving the group. Dreams therefore may be either personal or collective.

Thus, myths contain images or **archetypes** (to use Jung's term, which embraces Freud's concept of symbols)—traditional expressions of collective dreams, developed over thousands of years, of symbols on which the society as a whole has come to depend. For Jung the Oedipus complex was the first archetype that Freud discovered. There are many such archetypes in Greek mythology and in dreams. Here are some of the ways in which Jung thought about archetypes, the collective unconscious, and mythology. An archetype is a kind of dramatic abbreviation of the patterns involved in a whole story or situation, including the way it develops and how it ends; it is a behavior pattern, an inherited scheme of functioning. Just as a bird has the physical and mental attributes of a bird and builds its nest in a characteristic way, so human beings by nature and by instinct are born with predictable and identifiable characteristics (cf. Xenophanes, translated on p. 139). In the case of human behavior and attitudes, the patterns are expressed in archetypal images or forms. The archetypes of behavior with which human beings are born and which find their expression in mythological tales are called the "collective unconscious." Therefore, "mythology is a pronouncing of a series of images that formulate the life of archetypes."¹⁴ Heroes like Heracles and Theseus are models who teach us how to behave.¹⁵

The following are a few examples of archetypes. The **anima** is the archetypal image of the female that each man has within him; it is to this concept that he responds (for better or for worse) when he falls in love. Indeed, the force of an archetype may seize a person suddenly, as when one falls in love at first

sight. Similarly, the **animus** is the archetypal concept of the male that a woman instinctively harbors within her. The old wise man and the great mother and symbols or signs of various sorts are also among the many Jungian archetypes. These appear in the dreams of individuals or are expressed in the myths of societies.

The great value of Jung's concept is that it emphasizes the psychological dependence of all societies (sophisticated as well as primitive) on their traditional myths, often expressed also in religion and ritual. But Jung's theories, like those we have already examined, have their limitations; they are not the only key to an understanding of mythology.

The Legacy of Freud

Freud's theories about the origin of mythological themes have attracted devotion and criticism in the century since their promulgation—evidence for their undeniable importance. Classical scholars in the English-speaking world have been more dismissive than others: the important book by H. J. Rose on Greek mythology virtually ignores psychological and psychoanalytical approaches to myth, and the former Regius Professor of Greek at the University of Oxford, Hugh Lloyd-Jones, writing toward the end of the twentieth century, is skeptical, yet appreciative, of the work of other Regius professors (Dodds and Kirk), which is based on deep knowledge of Greek language and literatures and some knowledge of comparative sociology, psychology, and religion. Lloyd-Jones is contemptuous of psychoanalytical interpretations of Greek literature and myth by writers unfamiliar with Greek language and history. More gently, Jan Bremmer observes: "Historical and linguistic knowledge remains indispensable."¹⁶

From the beginning Freud has been under attack from biologists and psychoanalysts. E. O. Wilson, writing in 1998, says that "Freud guessed wrong" with regard to dreams and the unconscious. Wilson embraces the theory of J. A. Hobson that "dreaming is a kind of insanity," which in a way reorganizes information stored in the memory and is not an expression of childhood trauma or repressed desires. For example, in discussing the incest taboo, Wilson prefers "the Westermarck effect" (named after the Finnish anthropologist E. A. Westermarck, who published his theory in 1891 in *The History of Human Marriage*). Westermarck wrote that human avoidance of incest is genetic and that the widespread social taboo comes from this "epigenetic" attribute. In contrast, Freud believed that the desire for incestuous relations (in men directed toward their mothers or sisters) was "the first choice of object in mankind," and therefore its repression was enforced by widespread social taboos. Clearly, very different interpretations of the myth of Oedipus will flow from these competing theories.¹⁷ There will be other theories, and all of them, it can safely be said, will implicitly or explicitly support, attack, or comment on Freud. This is the measure of his genius.

For the purposes of an introduction to Greek mythology, however, arguments in favor of or in opposition to Freud and Jung are ultimately irrelevant. The crucial fact remains that their psychological and psychoanalytical theories permeate most profoundly not only mythological studies but all literary and artistic pursuits. They are arguably in some ways even more important and pervasive in intellectual fields than they are in the medical. Yet, a recent history of the rise of psychotherapy in the United States reveals how, within some 100 years, an

obscure treatment in Vienna has become “a staple of mainstream America medical practice and a fixture of our modern culture.”¹⁸

Freud’s theories have been a springboard for anthropologists and sociologists—most notably Claude Lévi-Strauss, whose theories have been applied to Greek myth with success by the so-called Paris school, namely, Jean-Pierre Vernant, Pierre Vidal-Naquet, and Marcel Detienne.¹⁹ These mythographers combine the study of human societies with psychological theories that explain the origins of myth in terms of the minds of individuals. (Jung was particularly concerned with the collective unconscious of society, as we have seen.) The work of these French scholars is fundamental for any attempt to understand the place of myth in human societies, but, like the theories of Freud and Jung, it overvalues similarities in the minds of individuals and collective rituals and myths of societies while undervaluing variations among individual human societies.

Before we consider Lévi-Strauss and other structural theorists, we begin with earlier mythographers who associated myth with religion and ritual in society.

Myth and Society

Myth and Ritual

J. G. **Frazer** presents a ritualist interpretation of mythology, which has become one of the most influential and enduring points of view. Despite its faults, his work *The Golden Bough* remains a pioneering monument in its attempts to link myth with ritual. It is full of comparative data on kingship and ritual, but its value is lessened by the limitations of the author’s ritualist interpretations and by his eagerness to establish dubious analogies between myths of primitive tribes and classical myths.

Similarly, the works of Jane **Harrison**, *Prolegomena to the Study of Greek Religion* and *Themis*, are of seminal importance. Harrison falls in the same tradition as does Frazer, and many of her conclusions about comparative mythology, religion, and ritual are subject to the same critical reservations. Frazer and Harrison established fundamental approaches that were to dominate classical attitudes at the beginning of the twentieth century.

Renowned novelist and poet Robert **Graves** has written an influential treatment of Greek myths that is full of valuable factual information unfortunately embedded in much fascinating but unsubstantiated and idiosyncratic analysis. For him the definition of “true myth” is “the reduction to narrative shorthand of ritual mime performed in public festivals, and often recorded pictorially on temple walls, vases, seals, bowls, mirrors, chests, shields, tapestries, and the like.”²⁰ He distinguishes this true myth from twelve other categories, such as philosophical allegory, satire or parody, minstrel romance, political propaganda, theatrical melodrama, and realistic fiction. We single out Graves because he was perceptive enough to realize that literary distinctions may be as enlightening as any other type of classification for classical mythology.

Yet, stated most bluntly, this ritualist theory says that “myth implies ritual, ritual implies myth, they are one and the same.”²¹ True, many myths are closely connected with rituals, and the theory is valuable for the connection it emphasizes between myth and religion; but it is patently untenable to connect *all* true myth with ritual.

Myth as Social Charters

Important in the development of modern theories is the work of Bronislaw **Malinowski**, who was stranded among the Trobriand Islanders (off New Guinea) during World War I; he used his enforced leisure to study the Trobrianders.²² As an anthropologist and ethnographer, he placed a high value on fieldwork in order to reach his final ideological goal: “to grasp the native’s point of view, his relation to life, to realize his vision of *his* world.”²³

Malinowski’s great discovery was the close connection between myths and social institutions, which led him to explain myths not in cosmic or mysterious terms, but as “charters” of social customs and beliefs. To him myths were related to practical life, and they explained existing facts and institutions by reference to tradition: the myth confirms (i.e., is the “charter” for) the institution, custom, or belief. Clearly, such a theory will be valid only for certain myths (e.g., those involving the establishment of a ritual), but any theory that excludes the speculative element in myth is bound to be too limited.

Structuralist Interpretations of Myth

Structuralism is a theoretical approach to mythology (first developed by Vladimir Propp), which has been explored with different emphases and approaches by various later theorists, among whom we single out Lévi-Strauss and Walter Burkert. Fundamentally, structuralism may be defined as an attempt to analyze myths into their component parts.

Claude Lévi-Strauss

More recently, the structural theories of Claude Lévi-Strauss have enriched the anthropological approach to myth, and they have a connection with Malinowski’s most important concept, that is, the link between myth and society.²⁴

Lévi-Strauss sees myth as a mode of communication, like language or music. In music it is not the sounds themselves that are important but their *structure*, that is, the relationship of sounds to other sounds. In myth, it is the narrative that takes the part of the sounds of music, and the structure of the narrative can be perceived at various levels and in different codes (e.g., culinary, astronomical, and sociological). From this it follows that no one version of a myth is the “right” one: all versions are valid, for myth, like society, is a living organism in which all the parts contribute to the existence of the whole. As in an orchestral score, certain voices or instruments play some sounds, while the whole score is the sum of the individual parts, so in a myth the different, partial versions combine to reveal its total structure, including the relationship of the different parts to each other and to the whole.

Lévi-Strauss’s method is therefore rigorously analytical, breaking down each myth into its component parts. Underlying his analytical approach are basic assumptions, of which the most important is that all human behavior is based on certain unchanging patterns, whose structure is the same in all ages and in all societies. He also assumes that society has a consistent structure and therefore a functional unity in which every component plays a meaningful part. As part of the working of this social machine, myths are derived ultimately

from the structure of the mind. And the basic structure of the mind, as of the myths it creates, is *binary*; that is, the mind is constantly dealing with pairs of contradictions or opposites. It is the function of myth to mediate between these opposing extremes—raw/cooked, life/death, hunter/hunted, nature/culture, and so on. “Mythical thought always progresses from the awareness of oppositions towards their resolution.”²⁵ Myth, then, is a mode by which a society communicates and through which it finds a resolution between conflicting opposites. The logical structure of a myth provides a means by which the human mind can avoid unpleasant contradictions and thus, through mediation, reconcile conflicts that would be intolerable if unreconciled. Lévi-Strauss would maintain that all versions of a myth are equally authentic for exploring the myth’s structure.

The theories of Lévi-Strauss have aroused passionate controversy among anthropologists and mythographers. His analysis of the Oedipus myth, for example, has been widely criticized. Yet whatever one’s judgment may be, there is no doubt that this structural approach can illuminate a number of Greek myths, especially with regard to the function of “mediating.” But the approach is open to the same objections as other comprehensive theories: that it establishes too rigid, too universal, a concept of the functioning of the human mind. Indeed, the binary functioning of the human mind and of human society may be common, but it has not been proved to be either universal or necessary. Finally, Lévi-Strauss draws most of his evidence from primitive and preliterate cultures, and his theories seem to work more convincingly for them than for the literate mythology of the Greeks. His approach is better applied, for example, to the early Greek succession myths than to the Sophoclean, literate version of the legends of Oedipus and his family. We should all the same be aware of the potential of structuralist theories and should be ready to use them as we seek to make meaningful connections between the different constituent elements of a myth or between different myths that share constituent elements. As we noted earlier, Lévi-Strauss was particularly influential on the Paris school.

Vladimir Propp

The structural interpretation of myth was developed, long before the work of Lévi-Strauss, by Vladimir Propp in his study of the Russian folktale.²⁶ Like Lévi-Strauss, Propp analyzed traditional tales into their constituent parts, from which he deduced a single, recurrent structure applicable to all Russian folktales. Unlike Lévi-Strauss, he described this structure as linear, that is, as having an unchanging temporal sequence, so that one element in the myth always follows another and never occurs out of order. This is significantly different from the pattern in Lévi-Strauss’s theory, where the elements may be grouped without regard to time or sequence.

Propp divided his basic structure into thirty-one functions or units of action (which have been defined by others as **motifemes**, on the analogy of morphemes and phonemes in linguistic analysis). These functions are constants in traditional tales: the characters may change, but the functions do not. Further, these functions always occur in an identical sequence, although not all the functions need appear in a particular tale. Those that do, however, will always occur in the same sequence. Finally, Propp states that “all fairy tales are of one type in regard to their structure.”²⁷

Propp was using a limited number (one hundred) of Russian folktales of one sort only, that is, the **Quest**. Yet, his apparently strict analysis has proved remarkably adaptable and valid for other sorts of tales in other cultures. The rigid sequence of functions is too inflexible to be fully applicable to Greek myths that have a historical dimension (e.g., some of the tales in the Trojan cycle of saga), where the “facts” of history, as far as they can be established, may have a sequence independent of structures whose origins lie in psychological or cultural needs.

Propp’s theories are very helpful, however, in comparing myths that are apparently unrelated, showing, for example, how the same functions appear in the myths, no matter what names are given to the characters who perform them. Mythological names are a strain on the memory. Merely to master them is to achieve very little, unless they can be related in some meaningful way to other tales, including tales from other mythologies. Dreary memorization, however, becomes both easier and purposeful if underlying structures and their constituent units can be perceived and arranged logically and consistently.

A very simple example would be the structural elements common to the myths of Heracles, Theseus, Perseus, and Jason, whose innumerable details can be reduced to a limited sequence of functions. It is more difficult to establish the pattern for, say, a group of stories about the mothers of heroes (e.g., Callisto, Danaë, Io, and Antiope). Yet, as Walter Burkert shows (see the following section), they resolve themselves into a clear sequence of five functions: (1) the girl leaves home; (2) the girl is secluded (beside a river, in a tower, in a forest, etc.); (3) she is made pregnant by a god; (4) she suffers punishment or rejection or a similar unpleasant consequence; and (5) she is rescued, and her son is born.²⁸

We can say definitely that in most cases it is helpful to the student to analyze a myth into its constituent parts. There should be four consequences:

1. A perceptible pattern or structure will emerge.
2. It will be possible to find the same structure in other myths, thus making it easier to organize the study of myths.
3. It will be possible to compare the myths of one culture with those of another.
4. As a result of this comparison, it will be easier to appreciate the development of a myth prior to its literary presentation.

Structuralism need not be—indeed, cannot be—applied to all classical mythology, nor need one be enslaved to either Lévi-Strauss or the more rigid but simpler structure of Propp’s thirty-one functions. Structuralism basically provides a means toward establishing a rational system for understanding and organizing the study of mythology.

Walter Burkert

Walter Burkert has persuasively attempted a synthesis of structural theories with the more traditional approaches to classical mythology. In defining a theory of myth, he developed four theses, which are in part based on structural theories and in part meet the objection that these theories are not adequate for many Greek myths as they have come down to us after a long period of development. According to Burkert, classical myths have a “historical dimension” with “successive layers” of development, during which the original tale has been modified to

fit the cultural or other circumstances of the time of its retelling. This will be less true of a tale that has sacred status, for it will have been “crystallized” in a sacred document—for example, the myth of Demeter in the *Homeric Hymn to Demeter*. In contrast, many Greek myths vary with the time of telling and the teller—for example, the myths of Orestes or Meleager appear differently in Homer from their treatment in fifth-century Athens or in Augustan Rome.

Burkert therefore believes that the structure of traditional tales cannot be discovered without taking into account cultural and historical dimensions. With regard to the cultural dimension, the structure of a tale is shaped by its human creators and by the needs of the culture within which it is developed. Therefore, the structure of a tale is “ineradicably anthropomorphic” and fits the needs and expectations of both the teller and the audience. (Indeed, as Burkert points out, this is why good tales are so easy to remember: “There are not terribly many items to memorize, since the structure has largely been known in advance.”) Further—and here we approach the historical dimension—a tale has a use to which it is put, or, expressed in another way, “Myth is traditional tale applied.”

This refinement of the structural theory allows for the development of a tale to meet the needs or expectations of the group for whom it is told—family, city, state, or culture group, for example. A myth, in these terms, has reference to “something of collective importance.” This further definition meets a fundamental objection to many earlier “unitary” theories of myth. If myth is a sacred tale or a tale about the gods, how do we include, for example, the myths of Oedipus or Achilles? Similar objections can easily be made to other theories that we have been describing. The notions of “myth applied” and “collective importance” avoid the objection of rigid exclusivity, while they allow for the successive stages in the historical development of a myth without the Procrustean mental gymnastics demanded by the theories of Lévi-Strauss.

Here, then, are the four theses of Burkert’s modified synthesis of the structural and historical approaches:

1. Myth belongs to the more general class of traditional tale.
2. The identity of a traditional tale is to be found in a structure of sense within the tale itself.
3. Tale structures, as sequences of motifemes, are founded on basic biological or cultural programs of actions.²⁹
4. Myth is a traditional tale with secondary, partial reference to something of collective importance.

These theses form a good working basis on which to approach the interpretation of myth. They make use of the significant discoveries of anthropologists and psychologists, while they allow flexibility in exploring the structure of classical myths. Finally, they take account of the historical development of myths and of the culture within which they were told. It will be useful to refer to these theses when studying individual traditional tales.

Comparative Study and Classical Mythology

Comparisons among the various stories told throughout the ages, all over the world, have become influential in establishing definitions and classifications. In the modern study of comparative mythology, much emphasis tends to be placed on stories told by preliterate and primitive societies, and too often the

developed literature of the Greeks and Romans has virtually been ignored. It was not always so; for pioneers in the field, such as Frazer (identified earlier), classical mythology was understandably fundamental. Our survey has shown that the comparative study of myths, especially by anthropologists (as opposed to philologically trained classicists), has been one of the most fruitful approaches to the interpretation of myths.

Oral and Literary Myth

The primary reason for the relative neglect of classical mythology is that many insist that a true myth must be oral, and some would add that it also must be anonymous. Today this is certainly the most persistent definition of all, with support from many quarters. Reasons are easy to find in an argument that runs something like this: The tales told in primitive societies, which one may go to hear even today, are the only true myths, pristine and timeless. Such tales represent the poetic vision, the history, the religion, even the science of the tribe, revealing the fascinating early stages of development in the psyche of humankind. The written word brings with it contamination and a specific designation of authorship for what has been passed on by word of mouth for ages, the original creator with no more identity at all. For Malinowski (discussed earlier), myths were synonymous with the tales of the Trobrianders, which they called *lili'u*, the important stories a society has to tell.³⁰ For those sympathetic to this view, folktales hold a special place, even those that have become a literary text composed by an author, who has imposed a unity (which may be suspect) upon a multiplicity of oral tales.

What has all this to do with classical mythology?

We do not concur with those who so narrowly define the word *myth*. We would not write a book titled *Classical Mythology* with the conviction that the literary texts that we must deal with are not mythology at all. First of all, myth need not be just a story told orally. It can be danced, painted, and enacted, and this, in fact, is what primitive people do. As we stated at the beginning of this chapter, myth may be expressed in various media, and myth is no less a literary form than it is an oral form. Furthermore, the texts of classical mythology can be linked to the oral and literary themes of other mythologies.

We have established that, over the past few decades, comparative mythology has been used extensively for understanding the myths of any *one* culture. Greek mythology, largely because of the genius of the authors who told the stories in their literary form, has too often in the past been considered as something so unusual that it can be set apart from other mythologies. It is true that Greek and Roman literature has certain characteristics that differentiate them from those of the many oral preliterate tales gathered from other cultures by anthropologists (discussed at the end of this chapter). Yet, the work of the structuralists has shown that classical myths share fundamental characteristics with traditional tales everywhere. It is important to be aware of this fact and to realize that there were many successive layers in the development of Greek and Roman myths before their crystallization in literary form. The Homeric poems, the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*, no doubt had oral antecedents.³¹ Often, and especially in structural interpretations, the earlier stages of a myth are discovered to have been rooted in another culture, or at least show the influence of other mythologies. For example, there are obvious parallels between the Greek creation and succession myths and the myths of Near Eastern cultures (we explore these parallels in the Appendix

to Chapter 4); such structural and thematic similarities do at least show how Greek myths are to be studied in conjunction with those of other cultures.

It is gratifying that comparative studies in the classics are becoming more and more abundant (as is made evident in our bibliographies), the focus being the identification of structures and motifs in Greek and Roman literature that are common to mythologies of the world.

Joseph Campbell

Joseph Campbell is the best known comparative mythologist to the general public, and his body of work embraces mythologies of every sort—oral, literary, whatever—in the world throughout the centuries. In his vast, all-embracing scheme of things, classical mythology is not of major significance, but it easily could be. He has done much to popularize the study of comparative mythology and is to be commended, even though, in his popularizations at least, he has paid less serious attention to the Greeks and the Romans. Perhaps he will appeal most of all to those who seek to recognize the kindred spiritual values that may be found through a comparison of the myths and legends of various peoples over the centuries. Although Jungian archetypes are fundamental to his approach, it is difficult to know how Campbell should be classified under our previous headings: with those who link mythology and society or religion or psychology?³² His inspiring influence on Martha Graham and her powerful re-creations of mythology in dance is discussed in Chapter 28 (available on the companion website). For a clear and comprehensive introduction to his numerous works, see Robert A. Segal in *Joseph Campbell: An Introduction*.³³

Gender, Homosexuality, and the Interpretation of Mythology

Feminist Approaches

Feminist critical theories have led to many new, and often controversial, interpretations of classical myths. They approach mythology from the perspective of women and interpret the myths by focusing especially on the psychological and social situation of their female characters. These theories share with structuralism a focus on the binary nature of human society and the human mind, especially in the opposition (or complementary relationship) of female and male. Social criticism of the male-centered world of Greek mythology goes back at least to Sappho, who, in her *Hymn to Aphrodite* (see p. 219), used the image of Homeric warfare to describe her emotions and, in her poem on Anaktoria, contrasts what she loves, another human being, with what conventional men love, the panoply of war.³⁴ In 1942, the French philosopher Simone Weil took basically the same approach in her essay on the *Iliad* (translated by Mary McCarthy as *The Iliad, or the Poem of Force*), focusing on the issues of violence, power, and domination, which are fundamental to Homeric mythology.

More recently, feminist scholars have used the methods of contemporary literary criticism, many of which are outside the scope of this present study (e.g., narratology and deconstruction), to interpret the traditional tales, associating them with the theories of psychologists (especially Freud) and comparative

Stages in the Development of Feminist Interpretation

Joan Breton Connelly, in her Acknowledgments for her book *Portrait of a Priestess*, thanks Mary Lefkowitz (p. ix), “who at Wellesley College, first opened for me the world of ancient women and Greek myth. Her thoughtful insights have informed this book throughout its writing.”³⁷

In her comments on “Gender, Agency, and Identity” (pp. 21–24), Connelly (following Lynn Meskell) identifies three stages in the development of contemporary feminist analysis, which are presented here essentially in her own words. The so-called first wave of feminism in the 1960s “focused on women’s political, social, and economic liberation from and equality with men.” A “second wave” in the 1970s and 1980s brought “new emphasis on the ‘inherent’ difference between men and women and the special bond between women and Nature . . . and tends to view women as a homogeneous, nomothetic group.” A third wave, deconstructive feminism, which arose in the 1980s and continues today, “has focused its energies on difference, plurality, ambiguity, embodiment, the transitory, and the disruptive.” Connelly’s book finds its roots in the “second wave,” when women’s studies, gender studies, and other newly established fields sought out long-neglected source material, her goal being “to collect and evaluate evidence for ancient women so that they can be reinstated into a long-term cultural history.” This worthy goal has been accomplished well, and her research stands as a fertile, seminal resource for future studies.

anthropologists. Many feminist interpretations have compelled readers to think critically about the social and psychological assumptions that underlie approaches to mythology. They have led to original and stimulating interpretations of many myths, especially where the central figure is female. The work of feminist scholars has led to greater flexibility and often (although by no means always) greater sensitivity in modern readings of classical literature. Helene P. Foley’s edition of *The Homeric Hymn to Demeter* is a good example of how feminist interpretations can be incorporated in an array of varied interpretative viewpoints.³⁵ Feminist authors, too, are creating new versions of traditional tales designed to illuminate their point of view about political, social, and sexual conflict between men and women in our world today—for example, the two novels (originally in German) by Christa Wolf, *Cassandra* and *Medea*. Nevertheless, some scholars (among them leading classical feminists) have warned against the tendency to interpret classical myths in the light of contemporary social and political concerns. For example, Marilyn Katz criticizes those who object on moral grounds to the apparent infidelity of Odysseus to his wife, saying that “such an interpretation . . . imports into the poem our own squeamish disapproval of the double standard.”³⁶

Feminist interpretations of mythological stories are often determined by controversial reconstructions of the treatment and position of women in ancient society, often making no distinctions between the Greek version and that of the Roman Ovid and thus embracing two civilizations inhabiting a vast area over a lengthy period of time. We single out two major topics that influence feminist theories of myth: the position of women in Greece and the theme of rape.

Women in Greek Society

Evidence for the position of women in Greek society is meager and conflicting. It is also virtually impossible to make valid broad generalizations, since the situation in sixth-century Lesbos must have been different from that in Athens of the fifth century, and as time went on women in Sparta gained a great deal of power. For a long time, we have been reading the literature and looking at the art, and for us, some of the revisionist histories today depict a civilization that we cannot recognize in terms of what little direct evidence we do possess, controversial as it may be. A good place to begin for one's own control of what little we do know with any kind of certainty is with a study by A. W. Gomme, "The Position of Women at Athens in the Fifth and Fourth Centuries B.C."³⁸ Following are a few basic observations to give a sense of balance to the controversy.

First, it is sometimes claimed that Greek women, because of their political status, were not citizens in the ancient world. This is not true. Aristotle (*Athenian Constitution*, 42.1) makes it very clear that in Athens citizenship depended on the condition that both parents must be citizens: "Those born of parents who are both citizens share in citizenship, and when they are eighteen years old, they are registered on the rolls." It is evident over and over again that in Greek society the citizens were very much aware of the difference between citizens and noncitizens (resident aliens and slaves) in the structure and benefits of society.³⁹ Women citizens, however, did not vote; to keep things in perspective, one should remember that women did not win the vote anywhere until the first quarter of the twentieth century. Were there no women citizens in the world before that time? in England? in America? It is only in the first quarter of the last century that women gained not only political but also legal rights equal to those of men, sad as that fact may be in our judgment of humankind. In Athens a woman citizen benefited greatly from the prosperity and the artistic expression and freedom of the democracy and empire. She was very important in religious ceremonies, some of which excluded the participation of males. Women did not always walk outdoors veiled,⁴⁰ a few became intoxicated, some had affairs, and many were very outspoken (amazingly so for this period of time in the history of Western civilization) about their own inferior position as citizens in relation to that of the males.

Those affluent enough used slaves (both male and female) to do the household chores and take care of the children. It is difficult to believe all women were illiterate. It is likely, however, that their education was different from that of the men. Much would depend on contingencies such as class and individual needs. (The women of Sappho's Lesbos must have been able to read and write.) Athenian women went to the theater, where they saw and heard vivid depictions of the strength of their character and convictions and debates about their rights. They also saw varied portraits, not all evil but mixed, as it should be, many of great and noble wives such as Alcestis in Euripides and Deianira in Sophocles' *Women of Trachis*, among others. In art, women appear idealized and beautiful, but not nude (as men could be) until the fourth century B.C. because of Greek mores. The mythological world of goddesses and heroines reflects the real world of Greek women, for whom it had to have some meaning, especially since their devotion and major participation in religious rites and worship were manifestly so fervent.

Joan Connelly (see box on p. 18 and further discussion on pp. 155–156) reveals how "a broadly accepted commonplace that Athenian women held wholly second-class status as silent and submissive figures restricted to the confine

of the household where they obediently tended to domestic chores and child-rearing" (pp. 3–4) has been in recent years successfully challenged and proven to be false by an impressive array of scholarly research. There are many reasons for this imposed "invisibility" and oppression: the misreading of well-known literary texts (Greek dramas, Thucydides, Plato, and Xenophon); the failure to distinguish between "separation" and "seclusion" and to understand the contradictions between cultural ideals and real-life social practices; ignorance about the active role of women in the economic sphere and the existence and nature of women's public speech in Athens; and misunderstanding of gendered space and social relations in the household. She convincingly argues that there is more than enough evidence (fragmentary though it may be) to prove that "priestesses spoke before Assemblies; fixed their seals on official documents; and, at least by Hellenistic times, and maybe earlier, took their honored places in the front rows of theaters. Instead of highlighting the women who led public processions, made dedications in sanctuaries, and stepped forward on festal days to perform rituals and initiate sacrifices, the focus has rested on women locked indoors" (p. 276).

Connelly insists that "all existing evidence must be considered, and its evaluation must take place independently from the prejudices that privileged texts [such as those mentioned earlier] promote" and warns against "the conscious or unconscious devaluation, even dismissal, of evidence that does not conform to the consensus view." She explains how this consensus view became entrenched: "Nineteenth-century classicists, projecting the gender ideology of the Victorian elite onto the Greek household, ended up in roughly the same place as twentieth-century feminists who employed a 'subordinate theory' construct for managing the material. The result is the widely accepted commonplace of silent, submissive, 'invisible' women, confined to the privacy of their households and wholly dominated by their men" (p. 275). (For an example of the results of "gender ideology" and conformity to the "consensus view," see note 40 at the end of this chapter.)

The Theme of Rape

The theme of rape has become a fertile and seminal topic. What are we today to make of the many classical myths of ardent pursuit as well as those of amorous conquest? Are they religious stories, are they love stories, or are they in the end all fundamentally horrifying tales of victimization? Only a few basic observations about this vast and vital subject can be made here, with the major purpose of insisting that the questions and the answers are complex.

In Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, Apollo's pursuit of Daphne is the first of the love stories in the poem. To some it is a beautiful idyll; to others, it is a glorification of male supremacy and brutality. Quite simply put, it can mean whatever one wants it to mean. Certainly, it has been one of the most popular themes among artists throughout the centuries because it is subject to so many varied overt and subtle interpretations, primary among them not necessarily being that of rape in the sense of the word today. The case is similar in the history of music; the very first opera was *Daphne*, and she has been a profound, spiritual inspiration in the years to follow.

The Greeks and Romans were fascinated with the phenomena of blinding passion and equally compulsive virginity. The passion was usually evoked by the mighty gods Aphrodite and Eros, who could gloriously uplift or pitilessly

devastate a human being and a god. The equally ruthless force of chastity was symbolized by devotion to Artemis. Usually, but by no means always, the man defines lust and the woman chastity. In the case of Hippolytus and Phaedra (among others), these roles are reversed.

The motif of pursuit by the lover of the beloved with the implicit imagery of the hunter and the hunted is everywhere and becomes formulaic, with the pursuit ending in a ritualistic acquiescence or the saving of the pursued from a fate worse than death, often through a metamorphosis. The consummation of sex need not be part of the scenario of this ancient motif, played upon with versatile sophistication by a civilized poet such as Ovid.

Many seduction scenes are ultimately religious in nature, and the fact that it is a god who seduces a mortal can make all the difference. Zeus may single out a chosen woman to be the mother of a divine child or hero for a grand purpose intended for the ultimate good of the world, and the woman may or may not be overjoyed. These tales are told from different points of view, sometimes diametrically opposed. For example, Zeus took Io by force, or their son Epaphus was born by the mere touch of the hand of the god.

There is no real distinction between the love, abduction, or rape of a woman by a man and of a man by a woman. Eos is just as relentless in her pursuit of Cephalus or Tithonus as any other god, and they succumb to the goddess. Salmacis attacks innocent and pure Hermaphroditus and wins. Aphrodite seduces Anchises, who does not stand a chance against her devious guile. It is possible, if one so desires, to look beyond the romantic vision of beautiful nymphs in a lovely pool enamored of handsome Hylas to imagine a horrible outrage as the poor lad, outnumbered, is dragged down into the depths.

The title for a famous story that has become traditional may be misleading or false. Paris' wooing of Helen is usually referred to as the Rape of Helen. Yet the ancient accounts generally describe how Helen fell quickly and desperately in love with the exotic foreigner Paris and (despite her complaints about Aphrodite) went with him willingly to Troy. Of course a different version can find its legitimacy, too, if an artist wishes to depict a Helen dragged away, screaming her protests against the savage force of a bestial Paris. The designation of the seduction/abduction of Helen by Paris as the "Rape of Helen" was established at a time when the word *rape* did not necessarily have the narrow, sole connotation it has today, that of a brutal, forceful sexual act against an unwilling partner.

The Rape of Persephone is quite another matter. Hades did brutally abduct Persephone, who did indeed cry out to no avail. Zeus and Hades saw this as the divine right of gods and kings. Demeter and Persephone did not agree. But a religious artist or critic might maintain that god's will is god's will, and it was divinely ordained to have Hades and Persephone as king and queen of the Underworld.

The present book bears testimony again and again in a multitude of ways to the light these Greek and Roman tales have thrown on our civilization. They explored countless issues and emotions (among them passion and lust) that were as burning for them (both men and women) as they are for us, in their own images, just as we explore them in ours. We are no less obsessed with the subject of sex than were the ancients, and our depictions certainly can be much more violent and ugly, yet often not so potent. Critics of classical mythology in previous generations sometimes chose not to see the rape; some critics today choose to see nothing else.

It is fundamental to realize an obvious fact that too often is completely overlooked in our rush to interpretative, righteous judgment about the message of a

story. The same tale may embody themes of victimization and rape or sexual love or spiritual salvation, one or all of these issues, or more. Everything depends on the artist and the person responding to the work of art: his or her gender, politics, philosophy, religion, sexual orientation, age, experience or experiences—the list could go on. A major contention of this book is that there is no one “correct” interpretation of a story, just as there is no one “correct” definition of a myth.

Homosexuality

Homosexuality was accepted and accommodated as a part of life in the ancient world. There were no prevailing hostile religious views that condemned it as a sin. Much has been written about this subject in this era of gay liberation, and fundamental works are listed in the bibliography at the end of the chapter. Dover, in his classic study *Greek Homosexuality*, offers a scrupulous analysis of major evidence for ancient Greece, much of which pertains to Athens. This fundamental work is required reading, but his conclusions need to be tempered by other more realistic appreciations of sexuality in the real world, both ancient and modern. Particularly enlightening because of its wider perspective is *Homophobia: A History*, by Byrne Fone. The remarks that follow concentrate on homosexuality in ancient Greece. There were similarities among the Romans but differences as well. The period of time stretches over centuries, and the subject again is vast, complex, and controversial.

A prevailing view persists that Athens (representing a kind of paradigm of the Greco-Roman world) was a paradise for homosexuals, particularly in contrast to the persecution so often found in other societies. There is some truth in this romantic vision, but homosexual activity had to be pursued in accordance with certain unwritten rules, however liberal they may have been. In Athens, a particular respectability was conferred when an older male became the lover of a younger man, and it was important that each play his proper role in the sexual act. The relationship was particularly sanctified by a social code if the primary motive was, at least ostensibly, education of a higher order, the molding of character, and responsible citizenship. Longer homosexual relationships between two mature men, promiscuity, and effeminacy were sometimes not so readily accepted. Some homosexuals were made notorious because of their behavior. Gay pride today could not approve of many attitudes and strictures about sexuality in Athens or for that matter in Greece and Rome generally.

In the mythology, as one would expect, homosexuality may be found as an important theme. Aphrodite and Eros in particular play significant roles as deities particularly concerned about homosexual love. Several important myths have as their major theme male homosexual relationships: Zeus and Ganymede, Poseidon and Pelops, Apollo and Hyacinthus, Apollo and Cyparissus, the friendship of Achilles and Patroclus, Orestes and Pylades (especially in Euripides' *Iphigenia in Tauris*), and Heracles and Hylas. In Roman legend, the love and devotion of Nisus and Euryalus is a particularly moving example. This is not an overwhelming number of such tales in the vast body of classical mythology.

“Our tolerance for explicit descriptions of sexual acts in the post-Kinsey era has encouraged the growth of a minor industry in the study of Greek homosexuality.” These are the words of G. W. Bowerstock in his perceptive review of a book by James Davidson (*The Greeks and Greek Love*) and another by Andrew Lear and Eva Cantarella (*Images of Ancient Greek Pederasty*), in which he includes an

excellent, brief survey of homosexuality in ancient Greece and important modern works on the subject. He ends with this insightful observation: "The sexual life of the ancient Greeks was as variegated and inventive as its resplendent culture. It was neither consistent nor uniform. To this day it stubbornly resists all modern ideologies and prejudices, and yet had its own principles of decency. In sex as in so much else, the ancient Greeks were unique."⁴¹

Female homosexuality in Greek and Roman mythology and society is as important a theme as male homosexuality, but it is not nearly as visible. Sappho, a lyric poetess from the island of Lesbos (sixth century B.C.), in the fervent and moving poem (p. 219) mentioned earlier, invokes Aphrodite's help to win back the love of a young woman with whom she has been involved. Her relationships with women are evident both in other poems and in the biographical tradition and have been the subject of endless interpretation. (For those interested in Sappho's biography, the ancient testimony is collected and translated in the Loeb Classical Library, published by Harvard University Press.) From Sappho comes the term *lesbian* and the association of Aphrodite with lesbian love.

Lesbianism is not so readily detectable in the mythology generally. On one hand, sometimes it can be deduced as a subtext here and there; for example, it may be a latent motif in stories about the strong bond of affection among Artemis and her band of female followers and in the depiction of the society and mores of the warlike Amazons. On the other hand, lesbianism in Greek history, while not as well documented as male homosexuality, nevertheless did exist, at Sparta for example, where the position of women was extraordinary in terms of freedom, education, and power, and lesbianism was recognized as a widespread practice. Laws strictly enforced marriage, rewarded child bearing, and promoted the family as the core of the city-state, and anyone who did not comply was stigmatized in various ways. Yet, homosexuality (both male and female), practiced within the bonds of societal demands, was encouraged and respected.

The Mores of Mythological Society

Rather than imagine what Greek and Roman society was like over thousands of years in its feminist and homosexual attitudes and then impose tenuous conclusions on an interpretation of mythological stories treated by many individual artists with different points of view, perhaps it may be more fruitful and fair to look at the mythology itself to determine if there is any consistency in the social values it conveys.

Along with its nonjudgmental acceptance of homosexuality and the beautiful stories it inspires, Greek and Roman mythology overall reflects the point of view of a heterosexual society, from the depiction of the Olympian family of deities on down. Homer's *Odyssey* is the most heterosexual of poems, and one must look long and hard to read any subtext to the contrary. So is the *Iliad* for that matter, although a subtext comes more easily. True, the poem turns upon Achilles' love for Patroclus, but both men are depicted as heterosexuals, leaving the bond between them open for others to read between the lines. Probably Homer takes their bisexuality for granted. Enhancing and illuminating the relationship between Achilles and Patroclus is Achilles' love for Briseïs amid the profound depictions of the couples Priam and Hecuba, Hector and Andromache, and, perhaps the most searching of all, Paris and Helen.

Homer sets the stage for the basic qualities of the literature to follow. The body of Greek drama, as we have it, is shot through with family and religious values, raised to lofty heights by genius. The great families of tragedy, to be sure, are dysfunctional and neurotic, but the ties that bind them together are those of man and woman, husband and wife, father and mother, brother and sister, son and daughter. It would be difficult to imagine more powerful familial and religious bonds than those in the legend of Oedipus. The mutual devotion between Oedipus and his daughters Ismene and, more particularly, Antigone is extreme. Equally powerful is the feud between Oedipus and his sons Eteocles and Polynices. Oedipus dies committed to God, and Antigone remains true to the memory of her brother Polynices because of family and religion. The legend of the *Oresteia* may be an even better example. The criteria by which Herodotus singles out Tellus the Athenian and Cleobis and Biton as the happiest of men are embodied in ennobling tales (translated on pp. 143–149) confirming the fact that marriage and the family were fundamental in the politics and mores of the Greek city-state (*polis*). Roman mythology is possibly even more dominated by religious, familial, and, we may add, patriotic mores, and yet, in Rome too, homosexuality was prevalent, especially in Imperial times.

We all read this vast body of classical literature in different ways, and this is how it should be. The texts have something to say to each of us because they spring from a civilization that is all-embracing (not merely bizarre) and all too recognizable and helpful in the face of our own issues and conflicts and their resolution, not least of all those between heterosexuals and homosexuals and men and women.

Some Conclusions and a Definition of Classical Myth

Our survey of some important interpretations of myth is intended to show that something of value can be found in a study of various approaches, and we have included only a selection from a wide range of possibilities. Others might be explored; belief in the importance and validity of diverse interpretations naturally varies from reader to reader. About this conclusion, however, we are convinced: it is impossible to develop any one theory that will be meaningfully applicable to *all* myths; there is no identifiable Platonic Idea or Form of a myth embodying characteristics copied or reflected in the mythologies of the world. The many interpretations of the origin and nature of myths are primarily valuable for highlighting the fact that myths embrace different kinds of stories in different media, which may be classified in numerous different ways.

We realize fully the need to study comparative mythology and appreciate its many attractive rewards, but we are also wary of its dangers: oversimplification, distortion, and the reduction of an intricate masterpiece to a chart of leading motifs. Greek and Roman mythology is unique, but not so unique that we can set it apart from other mythologies. In other words, it will illuminate other mythologies drawn from primitive and preliterate societies, just as they will help us understand the origin, development, and meaning of classical literature. We must, however, be aware of the gulf that separates the oral legends from the literary mythological thinking that evolved among the Greeks and Romans and also among their literary antecedents in the Near East. It is